

Chapter 73_2 - Jealous

Jiuying walked as leisurely as if taking a stroll, while Qiuyi behind her was panting and struggling with each step, her eyes red with anger: "Master! This disciple refused to let her enter, but she insisted on barging in! Even the barrier couldn't stop her!"

"How would I know why the barrier can't stop me?" Jiuying shrugged her fragrant shoulders with a gentle smile. "Could it be that the Divine Venerable welcomes my entry?"

"Stop talking nonsense! You deceiving demon, you..."

"Enough!" Chu Qingqiu reprimanded Qiuyi in a low voice, then looked toward Jiuying without saying much to her. However, Jiang Li at the side gave Jiuying an appraising glance.

She smiled and said: "So this is the divine beast that the young sect master brought back? I've heard a little about it even in Wu Mountain¹. Seeing it now, it truly is extraordinary."

Upon hearing the praise, Jiuying's smile grew even brighter as she raised her head with her hands behind her back, looking quite proud.

Jiang Li covered her lips and lowered her head, saying to Jiuying: "Since you are the young sect master's divine beast, could I trouble you to take care of the young sect master now? Please don't let her disturb the silver needles on her body."

"Fine. Seeing as there's finally someone with a sweet tongue, I'll go check on that yellow-haired girl." Jiuying twirled the hair at her shoulders and walked gracefully toward the pavilion.

"This divine beast is quite difficult to handle. Although she's signed a contract, she's extremely hard to tame. The young sect master's fortune will determine what happens from here on." Jiang Li's eyes sparkled as she spoke to Chu Qingqiu.

Chu Qingqiu nodded and patted Qiuyi's shoulder: "Qiuyi, go to the back courtyard and bring my newly acquired Snow Mountain Spring Tea to serve our guest."

Qiuyi looked aggrieved but could only lower her head and acknowledge the order. As she turned around, she nearly fell to the ground, then remembered that Jiuying had cursed her legs, making each step extremely difficult.

"Master, look what that demon beast did!" She stamped her foot in frustration.

Jiang Li covered her lips and laughed, lightly pointing with her fingertip to dispel the restriction on Qiuyi's legs, winking at her: "There, go on."

Although Qiuyi was still angry, she couldn't disrespect Jiang Li, so she suppressed her resentment, bowed, and turned to prepare tea.

"Medical Immortal Jiang is indeed eloquent." Chu Qingqiu's hair fluttered lightly as she pointed toward the bridge over the lake outside the courtyard. Jiang Li understood and they strolled inside together.

This bridge curved in nine bends and eighteen turns, giving them plenty of opportunity to talk.

"Divine Venerable, don't blame me for being talkative, but patients should know their own condition. Why are you hiding this from the young sect master?" Jiang Li said seriously.

Chu Qingqiu was silent for a while before saying: "If she truly knew that demonic energy had taken root in her body, I fear she would gladly go and cultivate the demonic path."

Jiang Li was puzzled: "The young sect master is a righteous cultivator. Knowing she has demonic energy should make her panic, not turn to demonic cultivation."

Chu Qingqiu didn't answer but lowered her head: "She has always been rebellious. I'm just worried."

"That's true. After all, she's the daughter of Sect Master Ning Tian², so her thinking must be different from ordinary people." Jiang Li nodded. She glanced at the clear lake reflecting the blue sky and felt her gossip-loving heart stir again.

"There's one more thing I don't understand. When the young sect master was unconscious earlier, I saw how worried the Divine Venerable was, but when she woke up, you acted as if nothing happened. Why is that? Surely letting the young sect master know the Divine Venerable cares for her wouldn't make her turn to the demonic path too?"

"Medical Immortal Jiang just said that I don't have much time left to live." Chu Qingqiu turned to look at her.

Being so close and making eye contact, even Jiang Li blushed a little. She sighed about how the Divine Venerable Chu Ling was wasting such a beautiful face while coughing and looking away.

"My thinking was shallow. The young sect master's soul is already unstable. If she also came to care for the Divine Venerable and then had to part from you, she would surely suffer extreme shock." Jiang Li, who usually heard many romantic stories, understood well.

Then her eyes rolled and she tilted her head with a smile: "So it seems the Divine Venerable now admits to having unusual feelings for her?"

"When did I ever say that?" Chu Qingqiu rubbed the jade bracelet that was already glowing, saying indifferently, "In my eyes, she's just an immature junior. Medical Immortal Jiang should listen to fewer romantic tales in the future - they affect cultivation."

"Hey, you can't say that! Treating patients and saving lives is so tiring - this is where the fun lies!" Jiang Li smiled sweetly.

Seeing that they had turned several corners and were about to exit the corridor, Chu Qingqiu suddenly stopped and took out an irregularly shaped white jade pendant from her chest, handing it to Jiang Li.

"What is this?" Jiang Li raised her pale brows and reached out to take it.

"This fell from the White Bone³ years ago. It's called the Cloud Opening Pendant. I want to ask Medical Immortal Jiang to keep it safe for me, and after I die, give it to Ning Fuyi."

Jiang Li's eyes widened as she shook the pendant: "What do you mean?"

Chu Qingqiu looked at the jade pendant and said: "Inside are some things she should know."

"Very well. Since the Divine Venerable trusts me so much, I will certainly not fail in this trust." Jiang Li carefully put away the pendant and sighed. "Having her know more about what you've done for her - what good would that do?"

"You're too stubborn." Jiang Li continued sighing.

"Perhaps I am stubborn." Chu Qingqiu lowered her long eyelashes, conjuring fish food to throw into the water, watching the fish eagerly surface to compete for it.

"But I was never doing this for selfish desires." Chu Qingqiu's voice was very small. "I only wish to protect her for half a lifetime, waiting for her to truly grow strong."

"After all, the path ahead she must walk herself. What she must bear, she must bear herself."

Jiang Li didn't know what to say, only gazing at Chu Qingqiu's profile, her heart growing sad because of these words.

"It's about time. Let's go back." Chu Qingqiu said, turning around.

Meanwhile, in the pavilion, Ning Fuyi's cold sweat had already been dried by the automatically fanning feather fan in front of her. Pinned down by the needles and unable to move, she could only lie on her back staring at the bed canopy in silent contemplation.

"Bear with it a little longer. You didn't see how dark your Divine Venerable Chu Ling's face was when she saw me holding you - like she wanted to devour me alive." Jiuying conjured a reclining chair from somewhere and placed it comfortably at the bedside, rocking gently.

"Stop adding fuel to the fire. The one who eats people is you, not Chu Qingqiu." Only Ning Fuyi's mouth could still move.

"You don't believe me?" Jiuying immediately became displeased upon hearing this. She propped herself up on her waist, pressing her soft hand to her chest. "Look here - there's still a wound."

Ning Fuyi was getting tired of lying down: "I can't see."

"Fine, fine. You'll definitely take her side." Jiuying spoke slowly in her zither-like voice, lying back down. "If you ask me, there's definitely something wrong between you two."

"What nonsense are you spouting?" If not for being controlled by the silver needles, Ning Fuyi would have sprung up.

"Why are you getting anxious? Though I, Jiuying, am not human, I've lived tens of thousands of years longer than you. My judgment is naturally sharper than yours. Unlike you, a foolish girl who can't see anything clearly."

Ning Fuyi's mind became chaotic, so she recited mental formulas to close off her hearing sense, no longer listening to Jiuying's words.

However, since Jiuying had formed a contract with her, the voice echoed in her mind again: "Still don't believe me? After I emerged from the Demon Eye, I inquired about who you people were. All the legends say that Divine Venerable Chu Ling is emotionally detached and extremely cold, yet she shows concern for you everywhere - how is that normal?"

"I hadn't thought in that direction originally, until I saw that look in her eyes when she saw me holding you. It even scared me, Jiuying." Jiuying used her hand painted with red nail polish to prop up her cheek, her lips curving upward.

"As a divine beast, could you not pry into others' private affairs? Besides, what kind of person is Chu Qingqiu and what kind am I? She's a revered Divine Venerable surrounded by admirers - how could she possibly feel anything toward me..."

Ning Fuyi closed her mouth, not wanting to say more, and let out a laugh instead.

"See, you're not anxious when facing death, but mentioning her makes you anxious. Right and wrong - I'll prove it to you myself." Jiuying wasn't angry and remained smiling.

Ning Fuyi shut her eyes tightly.

Footsteps came from outside, and after a while the door opened. Chu Qingqiu and Jiang Li entered one after the other, bringing the fresh air from outside.

"Time is up. The headache has been temporarily suppressed. As for a permanent cure, we still need to wait." Jiang Li said gently, stepping forward to remove the silver needles from Ning Fuyi. However, Jiuying was lounging leisurely in front of the bed, blocking her path.

Jiang Li smiled with pursed lips and lowered her head: "Could you please move aside?"

Jiuying glanced at her without moving her legs, only waving her hand. The reclining chair slid backward as if it had wheels.

Jiang Li shook her head, then stepped forward to collect the silver needles from Ning Fuyi. The moment the needles left her acupoints, Ning Fuyi felt as if all impurities had been cleansed from her body, leaving her refreshed and clear-minded.

She supported herself on the bed edge to sit up. When she looked toward Chu Qingqiu, she suddenly remembered Jiuying's words, so her gaze quickly darted away to look at Jiang Li instead.

"Thank you, Medical Immortal Jiang." Ning Fuyi said.

Although she didn't quite believe Chu Qingqiu's explanation about it being just soul damage, she knew that if Chu Qingqiu wanted to hide something, even celestial immortals couldn't pry it out of her.

"It's what I should do." Jiang Li smiled sweetly.

Ning Fuyi looked at Jiang Li, then at Jiuying, always feeling something strange in their gazes, but didn't ask further and got out of bed.

However, having lain down for so long, her body was somewhat weak. She had just stood up when she staggered, and Chu Qingqiu had already raised her hand to support her. Unexpectedly, a hand with red-painted fingertips reached out from the side, intercepting Ning Fuyi's arm.

In the next instant, Jiuying's figure inserted herself between the two, smiling: "Master, let's go home."

This address of "Master" not only made Chu Qingqiu's face darken and her palm clench, but also made Ning Fuyi's stomach churn violently. She immediately tried to shake off Jiuying, but the other's strength was considerable, forcibly embracing her arm completely.

Her narrow eyes swept up and down over Ning Fuyi: "Master, don't be anxious. I'll take you away right now."

Without waiting for Ning Fuyi to open her mouth to scold, she transformed together with Ning Fuyi into a red light and disappeared from the pavilion.

Chu Qingqiu stood motionless in place, emotions surging in her clear lake-like peach blossom eyes.

After a moment, the celadon vase behind her suddenly exploded, shattering into smoke and fragments scattered across the floor.

Footnotes:

¹ Wu Mountain (巫山) - A mountainous region, likely where Jiang Li practices medicine

² Ning Tian (凝天) - "Condensing Heaven," the original sect master name, referring to Ning Fuyi's father

³ White Bone (白骨) - Chu Qingqiu's weapon/spiritual tool